

Practice Paper 39 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Two details that the car park was a quiet, neglected place

1 mark each for any two of:

- “The shops above it were shut” — no human activity in the surrounding building.
- “The painted lines for cars had faded into pale ghosts of themselves” — the markings have been neglected for a long time.
- It is described as “the emptiest place in the neighbourhood” on Sunday afternoons.
- The “faintly drizzling October afternoon” implies no one would choose to be there.

Q2. [2] — Father’s character

1 mark — He values **appearances** / **composure**: he keeps his expression “polite” even when frustrated, rather than showing open anger.

1 mark — He is easily **frustrated** / has little tolerance for things that **do not go to plan**; the tightness of the expression shows that his patience is forced and finite.

Q3. [2] — “The voice of a man surrendering a long war”

1 mark — **Surrendering** suggests **defeat** / **giving up** — he has reached the point where he is no longer willing to keep trying.

1 mark — **A long war** suggests the lesson has felt **exhausting and drawn out**, as though it had lasted far longer than the twenty minutes actually spent.

Q4. [2] — “A separate species from the rest of the family”

1 mark — The phrase exaggerates the **difference** between the uncle and the rest of the family — it suggests he is **fundamentally unlike** them, almost as though he belongs to a different kind of creature altogether.

1 mark — It hints at his **gentleness, quietness and restraint**, which stand in contrast to the louder, more impatient family members (such as her father in the previous paragraph).

Q5. [1] — Small action showing he came better prepared

1 mark for any **one** of:

- He arrived with an **umbrella** (suitable for the drizzling weather).
- He brought a **small flask of warm barley water** for her.
- The narrator explicitly notes she “had not thought to bring” either of these things.

Q6. [2] — Two ways the uncle’s method differed (own words)

1 mark each for any two of:

- He did **not** put her on the bicycle straight away — he made her **walk it** first.
- He asked her **reflective questions** about where the balance of the bicycle lay, rather than simply giving instructions.
- He let her **sit and rock side-to-side** with both feet on the ground, to feel the balance, before pedalling.
- He proceeded **slowly** and patiently, rather than rushing into the activity.

Reject lifted phrases such as “walk it” without explanation; require rewording for full marks.

Q7. [2] — Effect of “businesslike”

1 mark — The word suggests the bleeding is **neat, controlled, almost orderly**, as though it were a routine office matter rather than a sudden injury.

1 mark — The unexpected pairing of **businesslike** with **bleeding** creates a **dry, slightly humorous** tone, and shows the narrator is observing herself with a kind of **detached calm** — perhaps because her uncle’s presence makes the injury feel less alarming.

Q8. [1] — Effect of the short sentence “This was a lie.”

1 mark — The abrupt, blunt sentence emphasises the narrator’s **honesty with the reader**, while contrasting with the **brave face** she put on for her uncle; it also shows, with a touch of **dry humour**, how determined she was not to disappoint him.

Q9. [2] — “The bicycle and I were not at war”

1 mark — Earlier in the text the bicycle had been a **struggle / opponent** — she had wobbled, fallen, and felt out of control on it.

1 mark — Now, for the first time, she feels **in cooperation / in harmony** with the bicycle; the two are working together rather than fighting one another, suggesting her growing **confidence and balance**.

Q10. [3] — Quiet, undramatic triumph (language question)

1 mark for identifying that the language is **understated / restrained / minimalist**, refusing to make a big show of the moment; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “with his hands clasped quietly in front of him” — the verb **clasped** and the adverb **quietly** present him as composed, even modest, in his pride.
- “a smile so small that I almost missed it” — the smile is deliberately tiny, suggesting that the uncle expresses joy through restraint rather than display.
- “He had let go. I did not know when.” — the most important moment is reduced to two short, plain sentences, with no exclamation.
- “Neither of us said anything for a moment.” — silence rather than celebration marks the achievement.
- “a gesture that might have been a wave or might have been a salute” — even his acknowledgement is so subtle that the narrator herself cannot name what it was.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q11. [1] — “Not really about a bicycle”

1 mark — The lesson was really about **patience, trust, and the value of being taught calmly by someone who believes in you** — qualities the narrator now applies whenever she has to learn something difficult, not just to cycling. (Also accept: it was a lesson about how **quiet, gentle teaching** can succeed where impatient instruction fails.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “No longer remarkable... the new normal”

1 mark — Myopia has become so **common** / **widespread** among children that people have stopped finding it surprising or worth commenting on.

1 mark — In some places, having short-sighted children is now the **default expectation** — it is what people assume will happen, rather than an unusual condition.

Q13. [1] — Why the traditional explanation is popular

1 mark for any **one** of:

- It is **intuitive** / feels obviously true.
- It places the **blame on something the family can control** (reading habits, posture, screen time).
- It is **easy to repeat** as a simple set of warnings (“Sit up straight,” etc.).

Q14. [2] — Why such explanations appeal to families

1 mark — Families are **reassured** by the belief that the problem is **within their power** to fix — it suggests their child’s eyesight can be saved through better discipline at home.

1 mark — It avoids the more **unsettling possibility** that the cause lies **outside** the family’s control (e.g. in school hours, urban living, or lack of sunlight), which would feel more difficult to address.

Q15. [1] — Best-explaining factor

1 mark — The number of **hours spent outdoors** / in **natural daylight** each day. (Reject answers that name reading, screens, or genetics.)

Q16. [2] — How sunlight helps (own words)

1 mark — Bright outdoor light **stimulates** / **triggers** the eye to release a **chemical** / substance.

1 mark — This chemical helps the eyeball to **grow in its correct, healthy shape**, so that it does not elongate in the way that causes short-sightedness.

Reject lifted phrases such as “release of a chemical in the eye” without rewording.

Q17. [2] — Why the cure is “politically awkward”

1 mark — Reducing time at desks means **changing the school day** — moving away from a culture of long study hours that parents, teachers and ministries have traditionally encouraged.

1 mark — It is **awkward** because it requires authorities to **publicly accept** that pushing children to study harder and longer has had unintended health consequences, which is uncomfortable to admit.

Q18. [1] — Evidence Taiwan’s policy worked

1 mark — After mandating at least **eighty minutes** of outdoor time per day, the **proportion of new myopia cases** among Taiwanese schoolchildren began **to fall** for the first time in decades.

Q19. [2] — How orthokeratology works (own words)

1 mark — The child wears **pecially shaped contact lenses** during the night while sleeping.

1 mark — These lenses **gently reshape the cornea** (the front of the eye), so that when the lenses are taken out in the morning, the child can see clearly through the day without glasses.

Q20. [1] — Why outdoor time even on cloudy days

1 mark — Even on cloudy days, **outdoor light is far brighter than indoor lighting**, so children still receive significantly more of the bright light their eyes need.

Q21. [2] — Effect of the three short final sentences

1 mark — The three **short, blunt, imperative sentences** make the writer's advice feel **urgent, simple and direct**, contrasting with the longer, more analytical sentences of the rest of the article.

1 mark — The **repetition** of "Open the..." and the build-up to "Send the children outside" gives the ending a **memorable, almost slogan-like quality**, leaving the reader with a single clear instruction. (Also accept: it underlines the writer's argument that the solution is **strikingly low-tech**.)

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.

Causes (Paragraph 3):

1. The main cause appears to be **insufficient time spent outdoors in natural daylight**, rather than reading or screens alone.
2. Bright sunlight triggers a **chemical in the eye** that helps the **eyeball grow in its proper shape**; without it, the eye elongates and becomes short-sighted.

School-based prevention (Paragraph 4):

3. Schools can **mandate daily outdoor time** (Taiwan: eighty minutes a day) and **outdoor recess**, leading to falling rates of new myopia.
4. Specific schemes such as **"Read Outdoors"** and **"Outdoor Recess"** (Singapore) help shift learning time outdoors.

Clinical interventions (Paragraph 5):

5. **Orthokeratology** — overnight contact lenses gently reshape the cornea, giving clear vision by day.
6. **Low-dose atropine eye drops** slow the elongation of the eyeball and roughly halve the progression of myopia.

Home / family advice (Paragraph 6):

7. Families should ensure **one to two hours of daylight outdoor activity** each day, and apply the **twenty-twenty-twenty rule** during close work.
8. Parents should keep books and screens at **sensible distances in well-lit rooms** and arrange **early eye checks** before symptoms appear.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Research now suggests that childhood short-sightedness is caused mainly by a lack of bright daylight, which normally triggers a chemical that keeps the eyeball growing in shape. Schools can help by scheduling daily outdoor recess, as Taiwan and Singapore have done. Clinics now offer overnight reshaping lenses and very dilute atropine drops, which roughly halve progression. At home, families should ensure outdoor play, rest the eyes every twenty minutes, light rooms well, and arrange early eye checks.

Length count: 78 words from “Research” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —